

Data Management Policy

Harikar NGO

2025



Revision 1: December 2025

1. Introduction

This Data Management Policy outlines the principles and practices that Harikar Organization follows to manage, protect, and govern data and information assets. The policy applies to all types of data both hard copies (physical documents) and soft copies (digital data) generated, collected, or received by the organization in the course of its operations.

Maintaining the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of information is critical to our accountability, operational efficiency, and the protection of beneficiaries, staff, and partners.

Donor-Specific Data Protection Requirements

Harikar recognizes that many donors maintain their own data protection, privacy, and information management requirements as part of their grant agreements. Accordingly, for each donor-funded project, Harikar shall, as a matter of principle, comply with the applicable donor's data protection and information management policy, procedures, and contractual obligations. Where this Data Management Policy establishes additional internal controls or where donor requirements are silent or less comprehensive, Harikar personnel shall also comply with this Policy, provided there is no conflict with the donor's mandatory requirements.

2. Objectives

- a) Ensure accurate, secure, and accessible data management systems.
- b) Prevent unauthorized access, loss, or misuse of data.
- c) Promote transparency and accountability in data handling.
- d) Comply with donor requirements, legal obligations, and best practices.

2.1 2. Definitions

For the purposes of this Policy, the following definitions shall apply:

2.1 Data

Any information, whether in physical or electronic form, that is created, collected, received, processed, stored, shared, or disposed of by Harikar in the course of its operations.

2.2 Personal Data

Any information relating to an identified or identifiable natural person ("data subject"). A person is considered identifiable if they can be identified directly or indirectly by reference to identifiers such as a name, identification number, location data, online identifier, photograph, or one or more factors specific to their physical, physiological, genetic, mental, economic, cultural, or social identity.

2.3 Sensitive Personal Data (Special Category Data)

Personal data that requires enhanced protection because unauthorized disclosure could cause significant harm to an individual. This includes, where applicable, information relating to:

- Ethnic or racial origin;
- Religious or political beliefs;
- Health or medical conditions;
- Disability status;
- Biometric or genetic data;
- Sexual orientation or gender identity;
- Criminal allegations or convictions, where legally permitted;
- Protection case management records;
- Gender-Based Violence (GBV), Child Protection (CP), or Protection from Sexual Exploitation and Abuse (PSEA) case information; and
- Any other information classified as sensitive under applicable law or donor requirements.

2.4 Data Subject

Any living individual whose personal data is collected, processed, stored, or otherwise handled by Harikar. This may include beneficiaries, employees, volunteers, consultants, job applicants, interns, suppliers, contractors, partners, and other individuals.

2.5 Data Processing

Any operation or set of operations performed on data, whether by automated or manual means, including collection, recording, organization, structuring, storage, adaptation, retrieval, consultation, use, sharing, transmission, disclosure, restriction, archiving, deletion, or destruction.

2.6 Data Controller

The organization or entity that determines the purposes and means of processing personal data. Unless otherwise specified in a donor agreement, Harikar is generally the Data Controller for personal data collected through its operations.

2.7 Data Processor

A person or organization that processes personal data on behalf of the Data Controller, such as cloud service providers, consultants, IT service providers, or other contracted entities.

2.8 Data Protection Focal Point

The staff member designated by Harikar to oversee implementation of this Policy, provide advice on data protection matters, coordinate breach management, monitor compliance, and serve as the primary contact for data protection issues within the organization.

2.9 Confidential Information

Any information that is not intended for public disclosure and that could reasonably be expected to cause harm to individuals, Harikar, donors, partners, or other stakeholders if accessed, disclosed, altered, or destroyed without authorization.

2.10 Data Breach

Any accidental or unlawful destruction, loss, alteration, unauthorized disclosure of, or unauthorized access to personal, confidential, or sensitive information, whether stored electronically or in physical form.

2.11 Information Asset

Any information, record, database, document, system, application, or storage medium that has value to Harikar and supports its programmes, operations, legal obligations, or decision-making processes.

2.12 Data Retention

The practice of keeping data only for the period necessary to fulfil legal, contractual, operational, or donor requirements before it is securely archived or destroyed.

2.13 Data Disposal

The secure destruction or permanent deletion of data in a manner that prevents unauthorized access, recovery, or reconstruction.

2.14 Anonymization

The process of permanently removing or modifying personal identifiers so that an individual can no longer be identified, directly or indirectly.

2.15 Pseudonymization

The process of replacing personal identifiers with codes or other identifiers so that data cannot be attributed to a specific individual without additional information that is kept separately and securely.

2.16 Need-to-Know Principle

The principle that access to information shall be limited to individuals whose official duties require such access in order to perform their assigned responsibilities.

2.17 Least Privilege Principle

The information security principle whereby users are granted only the minimum level of access necessary to perform their authorized duties.

2.18 Information Security

The protection of information against unauthorized access, disclosure, alteration, destruction, or loss through appropriate administrative, technical, and physical safeguards, ensuring confidentiality, integrity, and availability.

2.19 Donor Data Protection Requirements

The data protection, privacy, confidentiality, information security, records management, and data-sharing obligations established by a donor through grant agreements, contractual clauses, policies, or operational guidance. Where such requirements are applicable to a project, Harikar shall comply with them in accordance with Section 4.4 of this Policy.

3. Scope

This Policy applies organization-wide to all Harikar personnel. For donor-funded projects, the applicable donor's data protection policy, contractual requirements, and information management procedures shall take precedence where they impose more stringent or specific obligations. In all other respects, this Policy shall govern the management, protection, storage, sharing, retention, and disposal of Harikar data and information.

This policy applies to all staff, volunteers, consultants, and partners who handle Harikar's data, including:

- a) Programmatic data
- b) Administrative records
- c) Human resources and payroll data
- d) Beneficiary information
- e) Financial and procurement records
- f) Donor and partner communications

4. Data Management Principles

Harikar adheres to the following principles in managing data:

4.1 Confidentiality

All sensitive data especially that of beneficiaries, staff, and partners is treated as confidential and is only accessible to authorized personnel.

4.2 Integrity

We ensure data accuracy and completeness by implementing regular checks, backups, and version controls.

4.3 Availability

Information must be accessible to authorized users when required for programmatic or operational purposes.

4.4 Compliance

Data handling shall comply with all applicable national laws, donor contractual requirements, and Harikar's internal policies and procedures. For donor-funded projects, Harikar shall apply the donor's data protection and privacy requirements as the primary governing framework. Where donor requirements do not address a particular issue, or where this Policy establishes stronger internal safeguards that do not conflict with donor obligations, the provisions of this Data Management Policy shall apply. Harikar shall also apply internationally recognized data protection principles, including lawfulness, fairness, transparency, purpose limitation, data minimization, accuracy, storage limitation, integrity, confidentiality, and accountability, where applicable.

5. Hard Copy (Physical Document) Management

- a) All hard copies are stored in locked cabinets or secure rooms with controlled access.
- b) Sensitive documents (e.g., contracts, financial records, beneficiary registration forms) are only accessible to designated staff.
- c) No unauthorized copying or removal of documents is allowed.
- d) Physical records are archived systematically and disposed of securely through shredding when no longer needed.

6. Soft Copy (Digital Data) Management

- a) Digital data is stored on secure, password-protected systems, including local servers, cloud platforms, or encrypted drives.
- b) Access to sensitive files is controlled using user permissions and role-based access.
- c) Regular backups are conducted to prevent data loss.
- d) Antivirus software, firewalls, and encryption tools are used to protect against cyber threats.
- e) Laptops and USB devices carrying sensitive data must be password protected and encrypted.
- f) Staff are trained on data security protocols and digital hygiene.

7. Data Sharing and Transmission

- a) Data sharing must follow the principle of minimum necessary access.
- b) Any sharing of personal or sensitive information must be authorized and documented.

- c) Data shared externally (e.g., with donors or partners) must be anonymized when required.
- d) Email attachments containing sensitive data must be encrypted or password protected.

8. Staff Responsibilities

- a) All Harikar personnel are expected to handle data responsibly and in accordance with this policy.
- b) Any suspected or actual data breach must be reported immediately to the Data Protection Focal Point or IT Officer.
- c) Staff receive regular training and updates on data protection and security practices.

9. Data Breach Management

Harikar is committed to responding promptly and effectively to any actual or suspected data breach in order to minimize harm to affected individuals, protect organizational information assets, and comply with applicable legal and donor requirements.

9.1 Definition of a Data Breach

A data breach is any accidental or unlawful destruction, loss, alteration, unauthorized disclosure of, or unauthorized access to personal, confidential, or sensitive information, whether in electronic or physical form. Examples include, but are not limited to:

- Loss or theft of laptops, mobile devices, USB drives, or paper files containing sensitive information.
- Sending confidential information to an unauthorized recipient.
- Unauthorized access to Harikar's information systems or databases.
- Malware, ransomware, phishing, or other cyberattacks resulting in data compromise.
- Accidental deletion or corruption of important organizational data.

9.2 Identification and Reporting

Any staff member, volunteer, consultant, or contractor who becomes aware of a suspected or actual data breach shall:

- a) Immediately take reasonable steps to prevent further loss or unauthorized disclosure, where it is safe and practical to do so.
- b) Report the incident without delay to the Data Protection Focal Point and the IT Officer, and inform their immediate supervisor.
- c) Provide all available information, including:
 - Date and time of the incident;
 - Nature of the breach;
 - Type of data affected;
 - Number of individuals potentially affected;
 - Actions already taken to contain the incident.

Failure to report a known data breach may constitute a disciplinary matter.

9.3 Containment

Upon receiving a breach report, the Data Protection Focal Point and IT Officer shall immediately:

- Secure affected systems or physical records.
- Disable compromised user accounts where necessary.
- Recover lost or corrupted data from available backups.
- Prevent further unauthorized access or disclosure.
- Preserve evidence required for investigation.

9.4 Investigation and Risk Assessment

A breach investigation shall be initiated as soon as practicable to determine:

- The cause and circumstances of the breach.
- The categories and sensitivity of the data involved.
- The number of individuals affected.
- Whether confidentiality, integrity, or availability has been compromised.
- The potential impact on affected individuals, Harikar, donors, or partners.
- Corrective and preventive measures required.

Where appropriate, Harikar may establish an internal investigation team consisting of representatives from IT, Compliance, Human Resources, Programme, and Senior Management.

9.5 Notification and Response

Where required by applicable law, donor agreements, or contractual obligations, Harikar shall promptly notify the relevant donor, partner, or competent authority of a reportable data breach. Where there is a high risk of harm to affected individuals, Harikar shall consider informing those individuals without undue delay, including guidance on measures they can take to protect themselves.

9.6 Corrective and Preventive Actions

Following each confirmed breach, Harikar shall implement appropriate corrective measures, which may include:

- Updating security controls.
- Resetting passwords and access credentials.
- Applying software patches or security updates.
- Revising procedures and internal controls.
- Providing additional staff awareness or training.
- Applying disciplinary measures where negligence or misconduct contributed to the breach.

9.7 Documentation and Lessons Learned

All actual and suspected data breaches shall be documented in a confidential Data Breach Register maintained by the Data Protection Focal Point.

Each record shall include:

- Date of the incident.
- Description of the breach.

- Root cause.
- Impact assessment.
- Actions taken.
- Notifications made.
- Corrective measures implemented.
- Date of closure.

Senior Management shall periodically review breach reports to identify trends, strengthen organizational controls, and improve information security practices.

9.8 Data Retention and Disposal

- a) Data is retained only as long as necessary for legal, operational, or contractual reasons.
- b) Obsolete or redundant data is deleted from systems or destroyed (in the case of hard copies) in a secure manner.
- c) Retention timelines are defined in Harikar's internal archiving and records management procedures.

10. Policy Review and Updates

This policy is reviewed and updated annually or as needed to reflect organizational changes, new legal requirements, or evolving best practices.

Approved by:



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Executive Director
Date: 17 Dec. 2025